Why Berlin and Brussels keep butting heads

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Presented by HEINEKEN By GERARDO FORTUNA with ZOYA SHEFTALOVICH and NICHOLAS VINOCUR CIAO THERE. Gerardo Fortuna back with you, wondering if European

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CIAO THERE. Gerardo Fortuna back with you, wondering if European leaders' obsession with castles is becoming a full-blown fetish. Their latest venue is Slovakia's Trenčín Castle, where Ursula von der Leyen today joins the Visegrád Four presidents' summit for the first time.

In today's Playbook:

— Should've become a plumber? The new skills package unveiled by the European Commission might make you regret your career path.

— A leaked retirement list has the Berlaymont playing musical chairs — before anyone's even stood up.

— Faces in the crowd: Florika Fink-Hooijer, Prince Harry, Gert Jan Koopman, Roxana Mînzatu, Nigel Farage, Jared Kushner, Paula Pinho, Karol Nawrocki, Roberto Viola, Pascal Leardini, Friedrich Merz, Barry Andrews, Kerstin Jorna and more …

On today's Brussels Playbook Podcast: Zoya and Sarah explain why cybersecurity experts suspect Moscow is behind the attacks turning up the heat on Europe's supermarket freezers.

A message from HEINEKEN: Brewing in Europe means investing in Europe. HEINEKEN's value chain stretches from farmers and suppliers to breweries, distributors, cafés, bars and restaurants, supporting close to 430,000 jobs across the continent. Discover how beer and hospitality contribute to Europe's local economies and communities.

DRIVING THE DAY

BERLIN AND BRUSSELS SQUARE OFF: A dispute over the EU's future relationship with Canada is exposing a widening divide between German Chancellor Friedrich Merz and European Commission President Ursula von der Leyen, four diplomats granted anonymity to discuss the sensitive diplomacy

told Nick Vinocur and Zoya Sheftalovich .

The latest clash centers on von der Leyen's proposal to make Canada an "associate member" of the EU. Berlin objected to the label, and the tension ratcheted up after she repeated it at the summit in Montreal last week, just hours after Germany helped remove it from a joint statement approved by all 27 EU capitals.

The Kyiv connection: Merz had previously floated associate status for Ukraine as a step toward joining the bloc, an idea that was rejected by Kyiv. Officials in Berlin now see von der Leyen's use of the label for Canada — which effectively precludes using it for Ukraine — as a rebuke of the chancellor's initiative. A representative for Merz didn't respond to a request for comment.

Different definitions: The disagreement is about more than terminology. Under von der Leyen's definition, associate status would be for a country that could never join the EU — as she acknowledged in Montreal — rather than an intermediate step for Ukraine, two EU diplomats said.

Bigger than Canada: The clash sits among wider differences between the two over how the bloc should be governed. Berlin says it won't approve the Commission's proposed €2 trillion long-term budget unless "hundreds of billions" are cut. Germany has also backed a separate format with France and the U.K. for sensitive Ukraine-related matters, while von der Leyen's proposed European Security Council has failed to gain traction in Berlin.

"There is this institutional dilemma between Brussels and Berlin," said Jan Techau, head of Germany for the Eurasia Group and a former speechwriter for the German defense ministry. "Von der Leyen has taken a strongly integrationist approach to the EU while Merz has completely developed away from this and talks about the nation states as the primary driver of EU policy."

There's no sign of retreat on the "associate member" label: Berlin reiterated its objection at a meeting of EU ambassadors yesterday, two diplomats said, while a person familiar with von der Leyen's thinking said she has no intention of dropping the term.

Despite the rift, both sides share the same basic goals for EU-Canada ties, Commission chief spokesperson Paula Pinho said. A German diplomat agreed, saying: "We both committed to form a unique partnership that we don't have with any other country outside the European Union."

Shared ground, different instincts: Both leaders belong to Germany's conservative Christian Democratic Union, and Techau said they share "ideological overlap on many issues," including warmer ties with Ottawa. But he said Merz has "proven disappointing to people in Brussels who hoped he would take a more integrationist approach to the EU, and this has been driven entirely by domestic prerogatives."

The wider question: Techau said the label dispute reflects a broader argument over whether common EU institutions or national governments should drive policy. "The issue is, in many ways, 'unresolvable,'" he said.

BIG AND BREAKING

IS TRUMP'S LOSS LE PEN'S GAIN? The Republican wipeout in the U.S. midterms is a warning to Europe's incumbents that voters are in a mood to punish those in power over the cost of living , Marion Solletty reports from Paris.

Left hanging: Nigel Farage had been hoping to meet Marine Le Pen in Paris … but the French presidential hopeful is keeping her right-wing British ally waiting, Sam Blewett and Clea Caulcutt report.

METSOLA THE MEDIATOR: European Parliament President Roberta Metsola is pressing ahead with a visit to Poland despite the clash between President Karol Nawrocki and Prime Minister Donald Tusk over constitutional court appointments. Metsola plans to meet both leaders separately in Warsaw today, but her spokesperson declined to say whether she'll address the crisis with them.

Von der Leyen will also meet Nawrocki today, at the V4 presidential summit in Slovakia. The Commission has already made its position clear on the Polish crisis, EU officials said, and von der Leyen is expected to stick to it.

AI-PROOFING THE EU'S WORKERS

SKILLS GAPS COULD BE "LETHAL": Europe must invest more in education and vocational training to stay competitive in the face of pressure from countries such as China and the U.S., Commission Executive Vice President Roxana Mînzatu told Zoya Sheftalovich in an interview.

"It would be lethal for any society, for any economy, and for Europe as well, not to urgently address the needs in education," said Mînzatu, who is unveiling the EU's education and skills package today.

Plumb jobs: The package includes a strategy to make vocational education and training (VET) a more attractive pathway. Mînzatu said more than 70% of jobs in some sectors require vocational training, while people who choose that path have employability "close to 90%." Yet, she added, "parents, the society, kids do not see vocational training as the first choice."

In the AI age, a degree may not be the best ticket to a secure career: roles requiring physical presence, manual expertise and applied technical skills may prove more resilient, per the Commission's VET strategy.

Since generative AI tools took off in late 2022, vacancies have increased in fields including engineering technology, machinery mechanics, construction and transport. But those jobs are not immune to change, so education and training needs to keep pace with developments, the Commission will say.

Teach the children well: The package urges EU countries to make teaching more attractive, as student protests over teacher shortages flare up in France, Belgium and elsewhere. Most EU countries have teacher shortages, Mînzatu said, listing reasons including "unattractive working conditions, the wages, the salaries, the burden, the pressure of being a teacher, the pressure in the relationship that you have with a classroom, with the parents, with society."

The Commission cannot set teacher numbers or salaries, Mînzatu said, but wants governments to act on working conditions.

TALK TO PLAYBOOK: On the Brussels Playbook Podcast, Zoya asked people worried about AI what their game plan is for finding jobs. WhatsApp us on +32 491 050629 and listen from 7 a.m. to hear if we give you a shout-out.

20-SECOND PLAYBOOK PRIMER

The European Commission has presented the first EU-wide sustainable tourism strategy — but what is that? It aims to improve transport links to islands, coastal, rural and remote areas; make tickets for rail journeys easier to buy; improve high-speed and night train connections; and promote rail as part of the holiday experience. The Commission also plans to revise rules for air services, review airport legislation and make cross-border car rentals easier and more affordable.

GOLD WATCHES FROM THE COMMISSION

WHO'S PACKING THEIR BOXES AT THE BERLAYMONT? Forget the Commission work program. The hottest document circulating in Brussels' Signal and WhatsApp groups last week was a list of top EU officials supposedly heading for retirement, which set off a frenzy of speculation about the next round of musical chairs in the Berlaymont.

Playbook has seen the list. Gert Jan Koopman (DG ENEST) and Pascal Leardini (deputy SG of the Secretariat-General) could leave by year's end; Kerstin Jorna (DG GROW) and Florika Fink-Hooijer (HERA) in March; and Bernard Magenhann (DG JRC) and Themis Christophidou (DG REGIO) by mid-2027. Those nameddid not respond to requests for comment …

… except for Fink-Hooijer, who told POLITICO she's aware of the circulating list but stressed that no announcements have been made. "My age is mentioned on Wikipedia, contrary to that of many men — so nothing new here either," she added in one of this Playbook author's favorite replies ever.

Some smoke, some fire: Playbook set out to fact-check the list. Two EU officials, granted anonymity to discuss internal shake-ups, said Koopman has told colleagues he'll retire on Jan. 1. Two others called the timing of Christophidou's departure "accurate," despite pressure from her team to stay. One official said someone in Ursula von der Leyen's inner circle already has an eye on Leardini's job.

Meanwhile, three officials wondered why Sandra Gallina (DG SANTE) and Roberto Viola (DG CONNECT), both of whom have extended their tenures, were missing from the list.

Why the excitement? Because there's no room on the Commission's senior management career ladder. Former top official Catherine Day has proposed restoring fixed five-year appointments to get things moving, in her advice to von der Leyen on how to overhaul how the Commission works. With only one major reshuffle since von der Leyen took office, a retirement wave could finally get the Berlaymont's musical chairs spinning again.

Join us live today from 9.30 A.M. at the European Pulse Seminar, with voices like Michel Barnier, former Prime Minister of France, Aura Salla and Axel Voss, MEPs, Conner Rousseau, Chairman of Vooruit, and energy experts such as Linda Kalcher and Raúl Suárez. Discuss energy, AI and affordability, and help shape the 2027 European Pulse Poll by sharing your views in the live crowd-storming session. Be part of the conversation and register to follow the event online.

8 MORE THINGS GETTING US TALKING

GERMAN POLITICIAN FOUND DEAD: Police are investigating the sudden death of Bavaria's conservative deputy premier Hubert Aiwanger after his body was found in a hotel room in Berlin last night. Reuters

has a write-up .

ROYALS IN THE BUBBLE: Prince Harry and Meghan Markle head to the European Parliament on Tuesday to discuss online child safety and open an exhibition. It's the Duke and Duchess of Sussex's first visit to Brussels as a couple.

ZOOMING IN: Jared Kushner still hasn't set foot in Brussels, but he's becoming a familiar face on its video screens. An EU official confirmed Donald Trump's son-in-law joined a session of Wednesday's Ukraine talks remotely — his second virtual appearance here after dialing into July's Palestine Donor Group.

CAN A CHATBOT WRITE BETTER LAWS? Brussels is already putting AI to work drafting new rules and simplifying old ones, the Commission revealed in its latest red-tape review .

Meanwhile, in the Parliament ... Roberta Metsola is warning MEPs not to outsource their judgment to AI ahead of new guidelines on its use. Development Committee Chair Barry Andrews told POLITICO he has already drafted his own principles and invited others to follow.

CHERNOBYL'S €500 MILLION HOLE: The European Bank for Reconstruction and Development says international funding is urgently needed to repair the nuclear reactor and head off an environmental disaster after Russian attacks.

HUNGARY OPENS ITS SECRET FILES: Péter Magyar is releasing Communist-era secret police records , fulfilling a campaign pledge 70 years after the Soviet Union crushed the 1956 uprising.

FRONTEX'S EXPANDING FRONTIER: Plans to give EU border agency Frontex a bigger role in deportations, including to and from return hubs, are raising alarm among MEPs who fear that fundamental rights could be breached.

BRUSSELS CORNER

WEATHER: Mainly sunny. High of 11C.

THE ANTI-TINDER: Tired of swiping? International singles event company Thursday, active in more than 180 cities, launches in Brussels tonight. The concept: Get 200 singles into Jardin Hospice from 7 p.m., add drinks and flirting ⋯ and see what happens.

A new frontier for Brussels dating? The capital's dating scene may not be the wildest, but it certainly has its quirks — with romance blossoming in the unlikeliest places, including corporate parties, as I recently posted on LinkedIn .

Organizers promise no speed dating, no awkward matchmaking — just a party where everyone is supposedly single. And if tonight doesn't end in romance, there will be other events. Finally, some competition for Plux.

MICHELIN DINING ON A STREET-FOOD BUDGET: Festifood RTL makes its Brussels debut at Place de Brouckère tonight, bringing Michelin-recognized chefs and their creations to the streets. Opening-night dishes cost just €10, from blue-lobster rolls and truffle potatoes to shrimp croquettes and vol-au-vent. Entry is free. It runs from 6 p.m. to midnight, and continues through Sunday. Your wallet can thank Playbook later.

HOW TO EXPLAIN EUROPE: Italian speakers looking for an intellectual challenge can head to the Piedmont regional representation, Rue du Trône 62, at 6 p.m. for the presentation of Marinella Belluati's book on communicating about Europe through crises and transitions. Expect a gathering of Italian EU officials if you're up for some networking and, crucially, an aperitivo piemontese afterward — that last part needs no translation.

TOP OF THE PLAYBOOKS

Berlin: Friedrich Merz is under pressure to settle on a presidential candidate within days — and nobody has emerged to dislodge the CSU's Ilse Aigner as front-runner.

Paris: Emmanuel Macron will reportedly try to head off a Le Pen-Mélenchon presidential runoff by bringing other candidates together behind a single challenger.

Madrid: Far-right Vox is set to face a politically awkward audit finding , my colleagues have learned ⋯ while the party plays down ties to Donald Trump's Republicans.

London: As Andy Burnham arrives back from Antigua, Westminster is trying to make sense of what the U.S. midterms will mean for Britain .

Read more from our Playbook family: Washington ⋯ Ottawa ⋯ Canberra .

AGENDA

— Commission President Ursula von der Leyen participates in the summit of Visegrad Group (V4) presidents in Trenčín, Slovakia.

— The Commission unveils its education and skills package. Press conference with Commission Executive Vice President Roxana Mînzatu at 12:45 p.m. Watch live .

— European Parliament President Roberta Metsola visits Warsaw, where she meets Polish Prime Minister Donald Tusk at 4 p.m. and President Karol Nawrocki at 7:15 p.m.

— European Commission Executive Vice President Teresa Ribera and European Council President António Costa will join a high-level political dialogue between Latin American leaders and Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy in Madrid at 3:45 p.m. Ribera will deliver a speech at the Ibero-American Summit.

— Commission Executive Vice President for Technology Henna Virkkunen meets U.K. AI Minister Kanishka Narayan, DeepMind founder Demis Hassabis, Thomson Reuters Foundation CEO Antonio Zappulla and techUK CEO Julian David in London.

— EU-Western Balkans Ministerial Forum on Justice and Home Affairs in Budva, Montenegro. Press conference with Justice Commissioner Michael McGrath at 5:30 p.m. Watch live .

— Economy Commissioner Valdis Dombrovskis participates in a CEPS event presenting its 2026 Annual Overview Report on Simplification, Implementation and Enforcement in Brussels at 12:35 p.m. Watch here .

— Financial Services Commissioner Maria Luís Albuquerque attends the 10th High-Level Meeting on Union Restrictive Measures and the Sanctions Coordinators Forum.

— Startups Commissioner Ekaterina Zaharieva delivers a keynote speech at the Tallinn Digital Summit and meets Estonian Prime Minister Kristen Michal, Jordanian Crown Prince Hussein bin Abdullah al-Hashimi and Foreign Minister Ayman Safadi, and OECD Secretary-General Mathias Cormann.

— EU High Representative Kaja Kallas meets Portuguese Foreign Minister Paulo Rangel in Lisbon, with a press conference at 6:30 p.m. Watch live .

— Tourism Commissioner Apostolos Tzitzikostas attends the informal tourism ministers summit in Mullingar, Ireland.

BIRTHDAYS

MEP Caterina Chinnici; former MEP and Germany's Ambassador to Israel Alexander Lambsdorff; former MEP Goffredo Bettini; MLex's Lewis Crofts; La Croix's Céline Schoen; former Council of Europe secretary-general and ex-Prime Minister of Norway Thorbjørn Jagland.

Playbook is brought to you by POLITICO's EU Politics team: Gerardo Fortuna, Nicholas Vinocur, Gabriel Gavin, Zoya Sheftalovich, Max Griera, Mari Eccles, Hanne Cokelaere, Lucia Mackenzie, Gregorio Sorgi and Sebastian Starcevic. And: reporter Daria Zakharova, editors Alex Spence and James Panichi, and producers Dean Southwell and Hugh Kapernaros.

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